
Handout: E. J. Lowe – "Essentialism" (Ch. 6 of *A Survey of Metaphysics*)

Framing the Problem: What Are Essential Properties?

At the heart of this chapter is the **metaphysical distinction between essential and accidental properties**, a distinction that undergirds much of our common-sense and philosophical thinking.

- **Essential properties** are those without which an object could not exist.
- **Accidental properties** are those an object *happens to have* but could have lacked.

The Problem:

Lowe frames a *philosophical tension*:

- If we take the essential/accidental distinction as **mind-independent**, it leads to puzzling metaphysical issues (e.g., transworld identity).
- If we instead view it as merely **conventional**, then **our ontology dissolves** into arbitrariness, and we seem to lose any stable conception of what things are.

Thus, Lowe seeks a **middle path** that vindicates the essential/accidental distinction without falling into either metaphysical extravagance or deflationary conventionalism.

1. Two Notions of Essence (pp. 96–97)

Lowe distinguishes between:

1. **Temporal Essentialism**
 - An object has a property **at all times during its existence** and cannot lose it without ceasing to exist.
 - Example: The time of birth of an object may be essential *in this sense*.
2. **Counterfactual or Modal Essentialism**
 - An object has a property in **all possible worlds** in which it exists.
 - *This is the stronger and more metaphysically significant sense of essence.*

Lowe focuses the chapter on the **modal/counterfactual notion**, which plays a central role in modal metaphysics and identity across possible worlds.

2. Kinds of Essential Properties (pp. 97–98)

Lowe introduces two **categories** of essential properties:

- **General Essential Properties**
Properties *many objects* can have (e.g., being a dog).
These properties are “essential” if, for any object that possesses them, it could not exist without them.
- **Individual Essential Properties**
Properties that **only one object can have**.
E.g., being *that very dog* who first reached the North Pole.

Crucially, for a property to be *individually essential*, it must be such that **only one object** possesses it **in every possible world** in which that object exists.

3. The Necessity of Identity and Haecceities (pp. 99–103)

Lowe discusses whether objects have **essential properties that uniquely identify them across all possible worlds**—*their individual essences*.

- The key idea here is **the necessity of identity**:
If object $O = X$ in the actual world, then $O = X$ in *every* possible world in which O exists.
- A central example:
The property of “being identical with O ” appears to be an essential, uniquely identifying property—if such a property exists.

This introduces the **controversial metaphysical idea** of a **haecceity** (*thisness*):

- An **intrinsic, non-shareable** property that an object possesses in virtue of being *that very object*.
 - Haecceities allow us to talk about **transworld identity** without circularity:
An object in another world is O **if and only if** it has O ’s haecceity.
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4. Essentialism and Transworld Identity (pp. 101–103)

Why does this matter?

- **Transworld identity:** How can we say *the same object* exists in multiple possible worlds?
- Essential properties (especially individual essences or haecceities) offer a way to **track identity across worlds**.
If some property P belongs *uniquely and necessarily* to O, then in any world where P is instantiated, it identifies O.

This section illustrates how *modal essentialism* supports a **metaphysical account of identity** over and above linguistic or conceptual stipulation.

5. The Necessity of Origin (pp. 103–106)

This essentialist thesis is introduced via **Kripkean intuitions**:

- **Thesis:** If an object originates from a certain source, then it does so *necessarily* in any world in which it exists.
 - E.g., a tree T that grows from acorn A cannot have come from any other acorn in *any possible world*.
 - Lowe defends this claim with the **Four-Worlds Argument**, showing how denying the necessity of origin leads to absurdities about identity between trees in worlds where origins differ but other features remain constant.
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6. The Necessity of Constitution (pp. 107–109)

Lowe moves from origins to **material constitution**.

- **Thesis:** An object cannot have originally been made from a different set of parts than it actually was.

He uses the *Ship of Theseus* example to argue that **any change in the original set of parts entails a different object**—even if only one part differs.

- Attempts to weaken this thesis (e.g., allowing 3% variation) collapse under the **transitivity of identity**.

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- Result: Either we accept that **any change in original parts creates a new object**, or we allow **radical metaphysical permissiveness**.
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7. Identity Over Time vs. Identity Across Worlds (p. 109–110)

Lowe compares:

- Temporal identity (over time)
- Modal identity (across possible worlds)

He suggests a reason for **stricter standards** in the modal case:

- Time is **ordered**, allowing gradual change.
- Possible worlds lack any such ordering, so there's no clear way to track “gradual difference.”

This difference justifies treating **change over time** and **variation across possible worlds** differently.

8. Modal Logic and Accessibility Relations (pp. 110–112)

Lowe discusses the **modal logic principle**:

(1) If it is possible that it is possible that p , then it is possible that p .

He notes that rejecting this principle allows us to maintain that:

- *S could have had a slightly different origin*, without thereby implying that S could have had a *completely different origin*.

This involves refining **accessibility relations** in modal logic:

- If possible worlds aren't **equally accessible**, then not all nested possibilities collapse into single-level ones.

But Lowe is skeptical: if metaphysical possibility is **absolute**, shouldn't all possible worlds be equally accessible?

9. Evaluating Essentialist Theses (pp. 112–113)

Lowe takes stock:

- Both the **necessity of origin** and **necessity of constitution** have intuitive appeal.
- Yet neither can be **rigorously proven** without **already assuming** some essentialist premise.

This doesn't render them false, but it highlights the **limits of formal demonstration** in metaphysics.

10. Conventionalism vs. Essentialism (pp. 113–114)

Lowe ends with a **critique of conventionalist views**:

- Conventionalists say essentialist judgments reflect **cultural or pragmatic concerns**, not mind-independent truths.
E.g., calling an object “essentially an oak tree” merely reflects human biological interests.

Lowe's objection:

- Such a view **undermines objecthood itself**.
 - What does it mean for *an object* to be “redescribable” across radical changes?
 - How can we speak of identity at all without essential kinds?

He concludes that **essentialism has “common sense” on its side**, and perhaps is *required* to make sense of objecthood, individuation, and identity.
